

Flying with vials and cold packs: what the rules actually say

United States (TSA)

Medically necessary liquids, gels and aerosols are allowed in carry-on in reasonable quantities above 3.4 oz / 100 ml. Declare them to the officer at the checkpoint and separate them from other items for screening.

"Ice packs, freezer packs, gel packs and other accessories may be presented at the screening checkpoint in a frozen or partially-frozen state to keep medically necessary items cool."

Note: if partially melted or slushy, they may get additional screening.

Source: [tsa.gov/travel/special-procedures](https://www.tsa.gov/travel/special-procedures).

TSA does not approve products. Any case sold as TSA approved is using a phrase TSA itself does not use.

European Union / EEA / UK

Under EU Regulation 2015/1998, medicines and special dietary products needed during the trip are exempt from the 100 ml liquids limit. The exemption names medicines; gel packs are not named, so acceptance is at the screener's discretion.

Practical: keep vials in the sealed case, keep cold packs frozen solid, carry a short note or prescription if you have one, and ask for a manual inspection if you want to avoid the X-ray.

Source: European Commission, "Liquids, aerosols and gels."

What to say at the desk

- “These are temperature-sensitive medical items and the cold packs keep them cool.”
- Offer them for separate screening before being asked.
- Stay boring: a plain black case gets less attention than a cooler with a red cross on it.

Checklist the night before

- Freeze cold packs flat.
- Put vials in the case.
- Case into an insulated bag.
- Packs on both sides of the case, never touching glass.
- Whole bag in carry-on, never checked luggage (hold temperatures swing).
- On arrival: hotel fridge.
- Set a phone alarm for checkout titled “VIALS IN FRIDGE.”